Christina Rossetti

Anthology extension · Studying a poet’s wider body of work

New poet for Lesson 044. This is a separate source reader, not part of Lesson 037’s Emily Dickinson / Thomas Hardy anthology. All three original poems are public domain; questions and page design are newly authored by NOVA.

A Birthday

Christina Rossetti • original public-domain poetry

01 My heart is like a singing bird
02 Whose nest is in a water'd shoot;
03 My heart is like an apple-tree
04 Whose boughs are bent with thick-set fruit;
05 My heart is like a rainbow shell
06 That paddles in a halcyon sea;
07 My heart is gladder than all these,
08 Because my love is come to me.

09 Raise me a daïs of silk and down;
10 Hang it with vair and purple dyes;
11 Carve it in doves and pomegranates,
12 And peacocks with a hundred eyes;
13 Work it in gold and silver grapes,
14 In leaves and silver fleurs-de-lys;
15 Because the birthday of my life
16 Is come, my love is come to me.

Source: https://poets.org/poem/birthday

READING FOCUS · How do images of birds, fruit and colour build excitement? Which lines show the speaker’s feeling directly?

Remember

Christina Rossetti • original public-domain poetry

01 Remember me when I am gone away,

02 Gone far away into the silent land;

03 When you can no more hold me by the hand,

04 Nor I half turn to go yet turning stay.

05 Remember me when no more day by day

06 You tell me of our future that you planned:

07 Only remember me; you understand

08 It will be late to counsel then or pray.

09 Yet if you should forget me for a while

10 And afterwards remember, do not grieve:

11 For if the darkness and corruption leave

12 A vestige of the thoughts that once I had,

13 Better by far you should forget and smile

14 Than that you should remember and be sad.

Source: https://poets.org/poem/remember

READING FOCUS · Identify the volta at “Yet”. How does the last request differ from the opening command?

Up-Hill

Christina Rossetti • original public-domain poetry

01 Does the road wind up-hill all the way?

02 Yes, to the very end.

03 Will the day's journey take the whole long day?

04 From morn to night, my friend.

05 But is there for the night a resting-place?

06 A roof for when the slow dark hours begin.

07 May not the darkness hide it from my face?

08 You cannot miss that inn.

09 Shall I meet other wayfarers at night?

10 Those who have gone before.

11 Then must I knock, or call when just in sight?

12 They will not keep you standing at that door.

13 Shall I find comfort, travel-sore and weak?

14 Of labour you shall find the sum.

15 Will there be beds for me and all who seek?

16 Yea, beds for all who come.

Source: https://poets.org/poem/hill

READING FOCUS · Who asks the questions? Which replies offer reassurance? What does the question-and-answer form contribute?

Evidence challenge

Compare TWO of Rossetti’s poems: identify a shared concern, quote one accurate phrase from EACH poem, explain a difference in language or form, and finish with a carefully qualified judgement. Do not assume the speaker and poet are identical.